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+ CATEGORY: COMMUNICATIONS AND MARKETING TOOLS - COMMUNITY RELATIONS/PARTICIPATION - COUNTY BUDGET CIVIC ENGAGEMENT CAMPAIGN
+ ORGANIZATION: COUNTY OF RIVERSIDE EXECUTIVE OFFICE

+ NARRATIVE

RESEARCH

PLANNING

IMPLEMENTATION

EVALUATION

CONCLUSION

+ SUPPLEMENTAL

LAUNCH & PROMOTION

SURVEY & PARTICIPATION

WORKSHOPS

EDUCATIONAL MATERIALS

MEDIA, EARNED COVERAGE
& SOCIAL MEDIA

EVALUATION & RESULTS

BACKGROUND

During the 2024 budget hearings, we heard from residents who found the budget difficult to follow, and the opportunities to provide feedback on priority services were not conducive to widescale community participation. The feedback underscored the need to expand our opportunities for civic engagement, including education on how the budget works in a manner that was easy to comprehend. The expanded civic engagement plan was born. Over the course of eight months, we planned and implemented an outreach campaign that included a survey, workshops, resource guide and enhanced social media content.

RESEARCH

Secondary research included a review of public participation during annual budget hearings. Over a three-year period, the highest number of public comments was only 17. We also evaluated previous surveys on response rate, as well as perused budget resource guides created by other counties. **Legal research** guided the use of voter registration emails. **Demographic research** revealed Riverside County's population is 52% Hispanic, and 33% of the population speaks Spanish at home.

PLANNING

GOAL: Increase opportunities for community participation and education

OBJECTIVE 1: Write a community survey focused on priority services, deployed six months prior to the release of the recommended budget, and garner at least 10,000 responses.

OBJECTIVE 2: Conduct five budget workshops at least one month before the release of the recommended budget, reaching at least 500 attendees, and garner at least 250 public comments.

OBJECTIVE 3: Design, develop, and print a 24-page budget resource guide with graphics and charts, distributed to 500 people in person and 500 digital downloads by April 2025.

OBJECTIVE 4: Publish at least 10 pieces of social media content to encourage participation from campaign launch in December 2024 through budget adoption in June 2025.

GOAL: Ensure accessibility of budget information within the Spanish-speaking community.

OBJECTIVE: Develop Spanish communications materials, which will garner at least 500 surveys in Spanish, lead to distribution of 125 copies of the Spanish resource guides and receive at least six Spanish public comments during the budget workshops and budget hearings.

GOAL: Engender trust within the community regarding the budget process.

OBJECTIVE 1: Partner with 2 community-based organizations to deploy the survey and participate in the workshops.

OBJECTIVE 2: Partner with University of California Riverside's School of Public Policy (UCR) to provide an independent analysis of the survey results and produce a report in May 2025.

IMPLEMENTATION

SURVEY TACTICS

- The survey was open from Dec. 11, 2024 - March 31, 2025, via Survey Monkey for (digital dissemination) and community-based organizations (hard copy dissemination).
- Targeted Spanish speakers' responses via hard copies distributed by a community-based organization (CBO). In addition, digital dissemination of the survey was sent out by three other CBOs.
- News release issued and social media published in early December to announce the launch.
- Fliers were provided to all county departments to post in their lobbies and place on outreach tables, including community centers and libraries.
- Targeted email invites using registered voters email list and GovDelivery.
- Results were provided to UCR on April 1, 2025 (the day after the survey closed).

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IMPLEMENTATION (cont.)

WORKSHOP TACTICS

- Announced through a news release and social media posts in April. English and Spanish fliers distributed in community meetings, library branches, and department events.
- A video featuring all five county supervisors was produced in English and Spanish for social media.
- Workshops held in April in each of the five supervisorial districts. Four of the workshops were in-person and one was remote via telephone townhall. Spanish live interpretation was provided at each workshop.
- Take-home resources: Attendees were provided with a hard copy of the Budget 101, a relatable resource guide to understand the budget. A digital version was [available for download](#).

EVALUATION

GOAL FAR EXCEEDED: Increase opportunities for community participation and education.

- A total of 23,840 responses were received, of which 977 were in Spanish.
- The targeted GovDelivery email to voter registration list was sent to 654,584 recipients with 98% delivery rate and 391,405 unique opens.
- Eleven earned media stories.
- Five budget workshops, with 190 in-person attendees and approximately 19,000 callers during the telephone townhall, and a total of 261 public comments and 655 service area votes cast.
- The *Budget 101* resource guide was printed and distributed to 500 people at the in-person budget workshops. The digital version of the book was downloaded 1,259 times (1,229 English, 30 Spanish), exceeding our combined target of 1,000 by 75.9%.
- 12 pieces of social media content were created and posted from December through June that garnered 20,000+ views and hundreds of interactions.

GOAL EXCEEDED: Ensure Spanish accessibility.

- Materials co-created in Spanish, including four total news releases, 12 social media posts, survey fliers, workshop fliers, the Budget 101 resource guide and one video announcement.
- More than 975 survey results were received in Spanish, 125 Spanish copies of the *Budget 101* guide were disseminated (exactly 25% of all printed copies) and nine public comments received in Spanish.
- Earned media article from the largest-reaching Spanish media outlet in Riverside County.

GOAL EXCEEDED: Engender trust.

- The county partnered with four CBOs to support the deployment of the survey. The collaboration with TODEC yielded over 600 hard copy responses. The survey was even copied by a CBO and put out on behalf of a neighboring county.
- UCR produced an [independent analysis](#) of the survey results, delivered on May 9 and posted to the May 20 Board of Supervisors meeting.

CONCLUSION

By reimagining the budget process through strategic research, thoughtful planning, and inclusive implementation, Riverside County not only exceeded every goal but also built lasting trust with the community. With record participation, expanded Spanish accessibility, and new partnerships that strengthened civic engagement, this campaign demonstrated that complex government processes can be made transparent, approachable, and meaningful. The success of this initiative will serve as a model for future community engagement efforts, ensuring residents' voices remain at the heart of county decision-making.

LIGHT BLUE = CLICKABLE LINK



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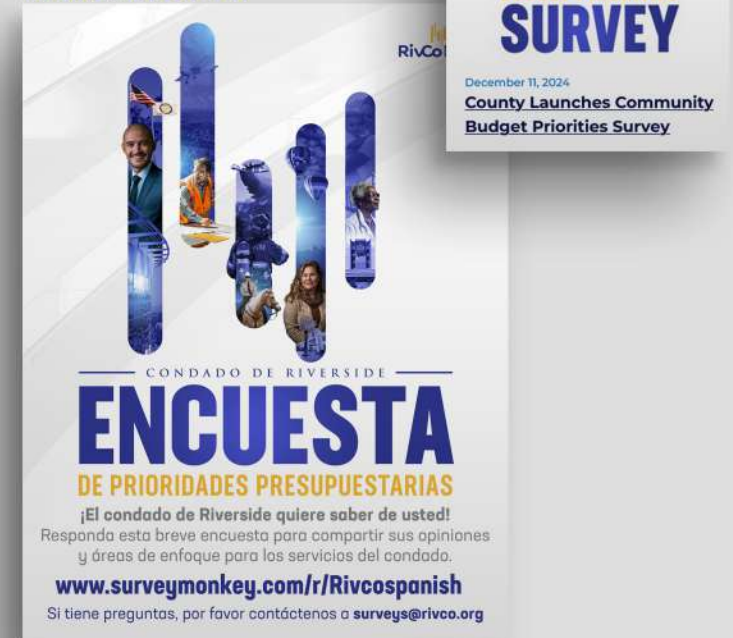
SURVEY FLIER



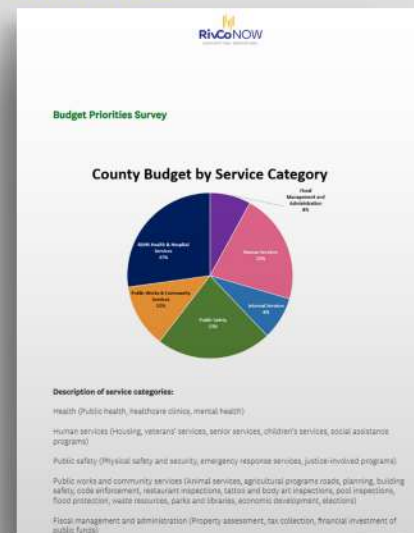
NEWS RELEASE



SOCIAL MEDIA POST



SURVEY PAGE





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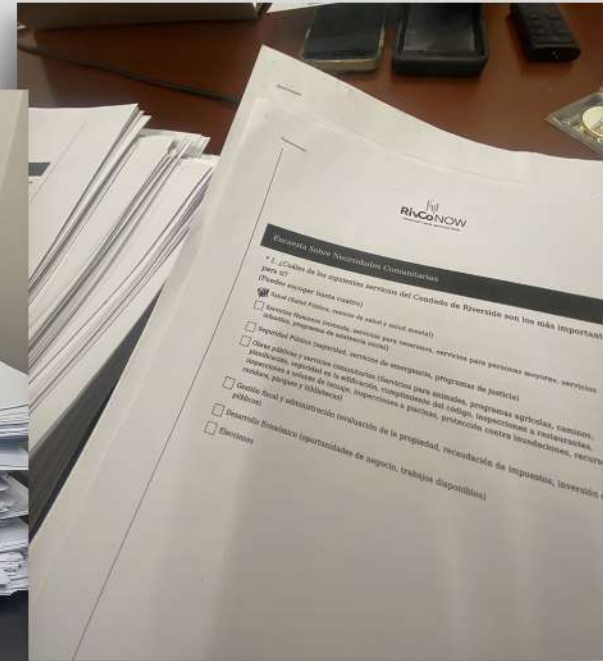
MEDIA, EARNED COVERAGE
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EVALUATION & RESULTS

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PRINTED SURVEYS



RESPONSES

23,840
TOTAL

977
SPANISH

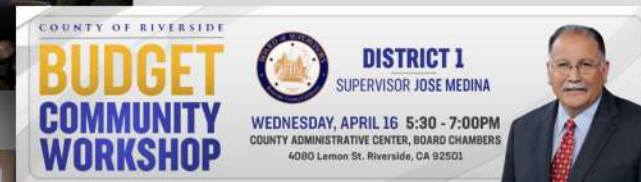


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WORKSHOPS



WORKSHOP FLIERS



BILLBOARD



ENGLISH & SPANISH VIDEO INVITATION



CLICK TO WATCH!

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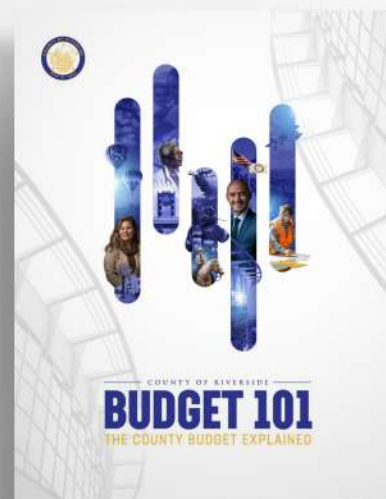
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LOCAL NEWS

RivCo Rolling Out A Survey; Seeks Public Input

December 11, 2024 12:06PM PST

f t SHARE

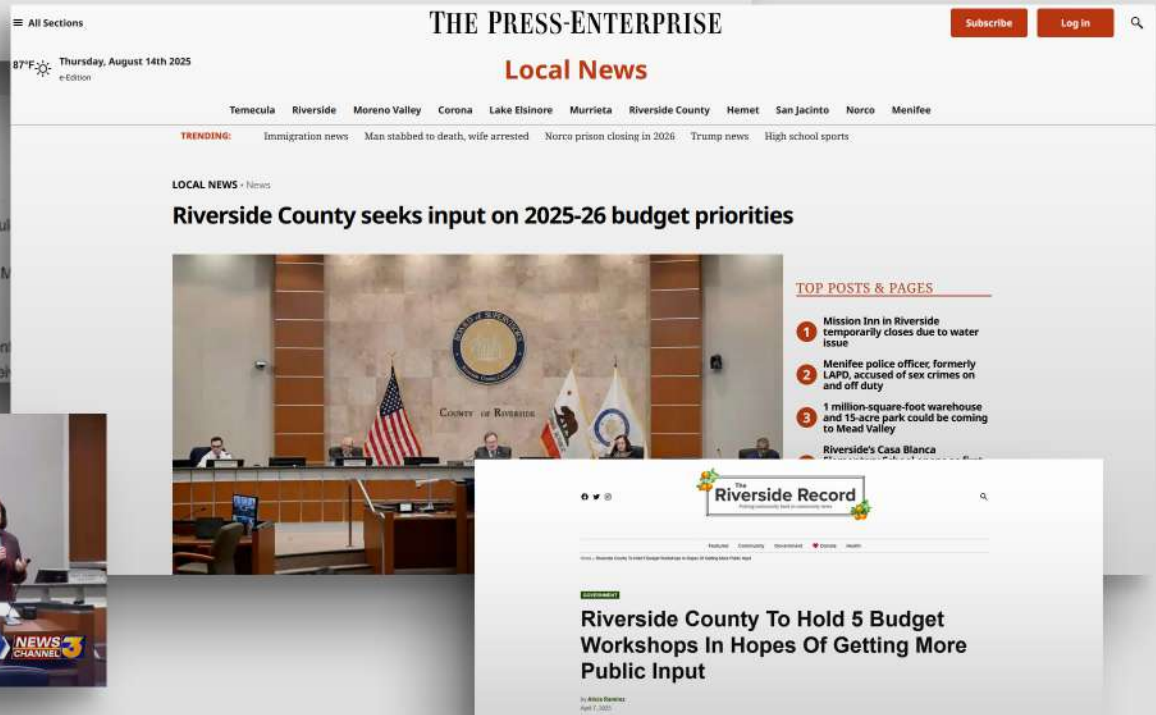
RIVERSIDE COUNTY LAUNCHES BUDGET SURVEY

IE Business Daily December 16, 2024

Riverside County is asking its residents to explain how the county should

The budget priorities survey began recently and will remain open until November 15. A statement on the county's website.

It is available online in both English and Spanish. Participants may identify services in their areas, as well as spending categories that should receive



IE Business Daily



THE PRESS-ENTERPRISE



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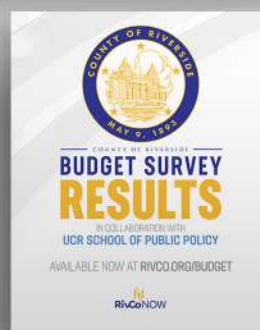
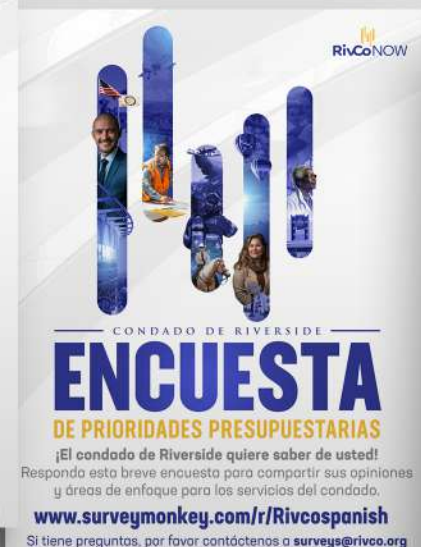
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SURVEY RESPONSES

GOAL: 10,000 RECEIVED

BUDGET 101 RESOURCE GUIDE

GOAL: 1,000 DISTRIBUTIONS

MEDIA PLACEMENTS

GOAL: 7 EARNED MEDIA ARTICLES

WORKSHOP ATTENDANCE

GOAL: 500 ATTENDEES

23,840 RECEIVED



1,759 DISTRIBUTIONS



11 EARNED MEDIA ARTICLES



19,190 ATTENDEES



SPANISH PARTICIPATION

- 125 Spanish *Budget 101* resources guides distributed
- 9 Spanish comments during workshops and hearings
- 4 Spanish news releases, including from largest-reaching Spanish media outlet in the county
- 12 Spanish social media posts, including fliers for surveys and workshops

CONCLUSION

An after-action survey was done among county department heads and fiscal staff, which garnered 88 responses. When asked if external communications demonstrated transparency and increased community participation in the annual budget process, more than 90% stated “agree” or “strongly agree.” One respondent said “Great attempt and success of community engagement.”

This level of transparency allowed our residents to truly engage with the budget process, understand how their dollars are spent, and even share feedback for future considerations.

SUPERVISOR CHUCK WASHINGTON, THIRD DISTRICT



The Department of Communications is doing a wonderful job of informing the people with what they need to know and what they are asking for! My rating is 1000%! Keep up the excellent work!

ROD DUTHOY, RESIDENT OF BANNING



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